

Chapter 3 — Delhi: 12th to 15th Century

The Delhi Sultanate

The one-line point: For 320 years, five dynasties ruled from Delhi — and the most interesting thing about them is **how they solved the loyalty problem**. They promoted slaves, barbers and cooks over aristocrats, because a man who owes you everything cannot inherit anyone else's claim.

← Ch.2 | Index | Next: Ch.4 →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval India
Sub-discipline	Sultanate period — political & administrative history
Period	1206 – 1526 (Delhi important from the 12th century)
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → dynasties, administrative terms, taxation, travellers
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ Administration, state formation; Persian chronicles as sources (asked 2020); women rulers
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★ ★ (mosques, Qutb Minar → see the Ch.9 supplement), Polity (centralisation vs. local autonomy), Indian Society ★ (gender — Raziyya), Economy (revenue systems)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ ★ — one of the most-asked medieval topics
Overlaps with	Ch.2 (Prithviraja's 1192 defeat begins this), Ch.4 (Sher Shah → Akbar), Ch.9 supplement (architecture)

 **Medieval India → Sultanate.** For Mains its strongest uses are **source criticism** (the *tawarikh*) and **gender** (Raziyya).

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

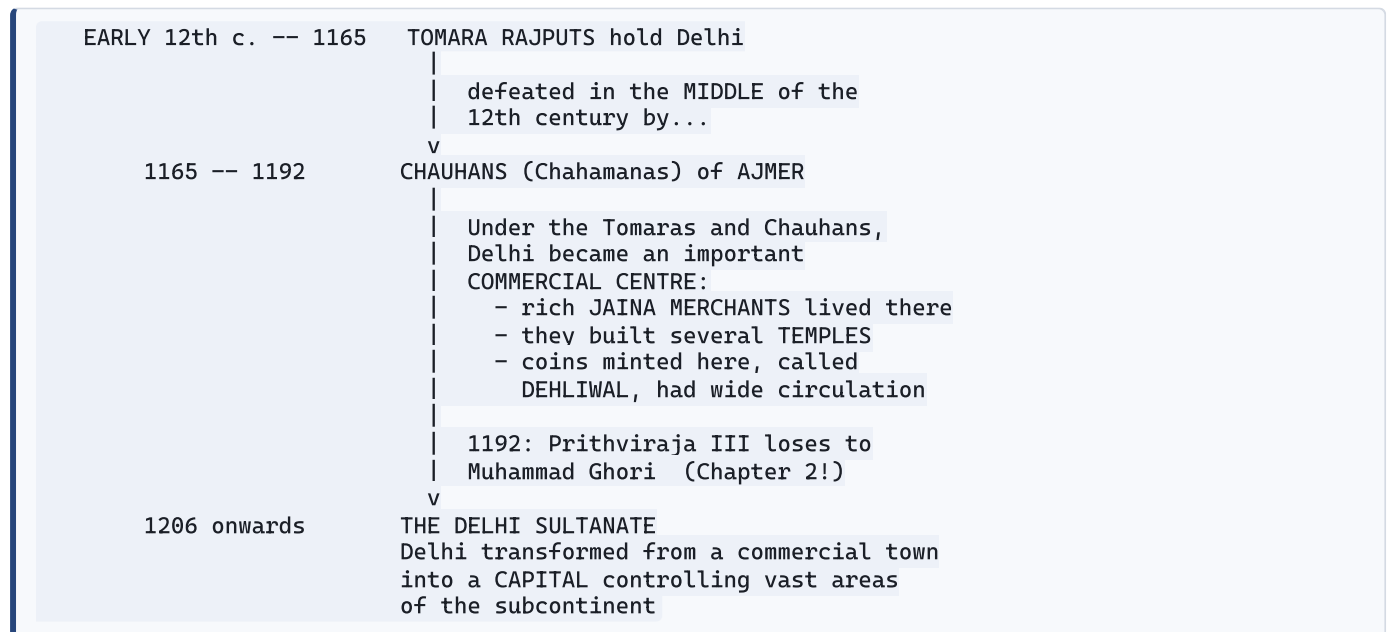
- ☐ **Explain** why Delhi mattered only from the 12th century, and name the **Tomaras** and **Chauhans**.
- ☐ **List** the **five dynasties** of the Sultanate in order, with approximate dates.
- ☐ **Define** *tarikh/tawarikh*, name the language, and state **three limitations** of these authors as sources. ★
- ☐ **Reproduce** the "**circle of justice**" argument and name **Fakhr-i Mudabbir**. ★
- ☐ **Narrate** **Raziyya's reign** and explain what **Minhaj-us-Siraj** objected to. ★
- ☐ **Contrast** Raziyya with **Rudramadevi** and **Didida**. ★
- ☐ **Explain** **bandagan** — what they were and **why Sultans preferred them to aristocrats**.
- ☐ **Explain** why that system also **created instability**.
- ☐ **Name** Muhammad Tughluq's low-born appointees and **Barani's** reaction. ★
- ☐ **Define** ***iqta****, ***muqti***/****iqtdar***, and list the controls placed on them. ★

- ☐ **State** Alauddin Khalji's revenue reforms and the **three taxes**, including *kharaj* at ~50%. ★
- ☐ **Define** *khums*, *zakat* and *jizyah*.
- ☐ **Distinguish** the Sultanate's **internal** and **external frontiers**.
- ☐ **Explain** the **Mongol** threat and its administrative consequence.
- ☐ **Describe Sher Shah Suri** and his link to **Akbar**. ★

📺 Start Here: Delhi Wasn't Always Delhi

Notice something about Chapter 2: it described the Kaveri delta, Kanauj, Bengal, the Deccan — **and never once mentioned a kingdom based at Delhi.**

That's because **Delhi became important only in the twelfth century.**



★ **Two details that get asked:** the **Tomaras** held Delhi before the **Chauhans**, and the coins minted there were called *dehliwal*. Note also that Delhi's early prosperity was built by **Jaina merchants** — a nice corrective to the assumption that medieval Delhi was purely a garrison city.

1 The Rulers of Delhi — The Five Dynasties ★ ★ ★

Learn this sequence cold. It is the scaffolding for everything else.

Dynasty	Period	Key rulers
Rajput dynasties	early 12th c. – 1192	Tomaras (to 1165), Chauhans (1165–1192)
1. Early Turkish rulers ("Slave"/Mamluk)	1206 – 1290	Qutbuddin Aybak (1206–1210), Iltutmish (1210–1236), Raziyya (1236–1240), Balban (1266–1287)
2. Khalji dynasty	1290 – 1320	Jalaluddin Khalji, ★ Alauddin Khalji (1296–1316)
3. Tughluq dynasty	1320 – 1414	Ghiyasuddin Tughluq, ★ Muhammad Tughluq (1324–1351), Firuz Shah Tughluq (1351–1388)
4. Sayyid dynasty	1414 – 1451	Khizr Khan (1414–1421)
5. Lodi dynasty	1451 – 1526	Bahlul Lodi, Sikandar Lodi, Ibrahim Lodi

🟡 **Memory hook: "Slaves Khaled Tughs, Said Lodi"** → Slave, Khalji, Tughluq, Sayyid, Lodi. Crude, but it sticks.

★ **The two names that carry most of the questions are ALAUDDIN KHALJI and MUHAMMAD TUGHLUQ** — they appear together throughout the chapter as the two most interventionist rulers.

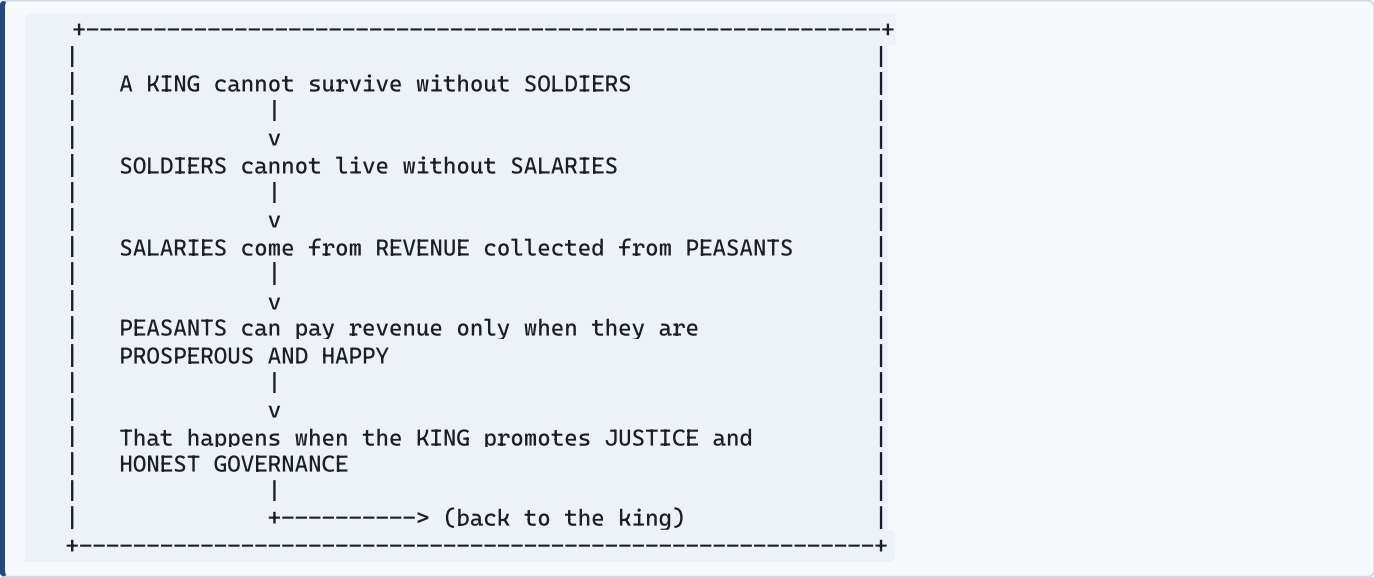
The Sultanate ends in 1526, when Babur defeats Ibrahim Lodi at Panipat → **Chapter 4**.

2 ★ ★ Understanding the Sultans: the *Tawarikh*

Term	Detail
<i>Tarikh</i> (singular) / <i>tawarikh</i> (plural)	Histories
Language	PERSIAN — the language of administration under the Delhi Sultans ★
Who wrote them	Learned men: secretaries, administrators, poets and courtiers
What they did	Both recounted events and advised rulers on governance, emphasising the importance of just rule

⚖️ **The "Circle of Justice"** ★ ★ ★

Fakhr-i Mudabbir, writing in the **thirteenth century**:



🎯 **Why this is such good material:** it is an argument for just governance made on **entirely self-interested grounds**. Not "be just because it is right", but *"be just because otherwise your revenue collapses and your army dissolves."*

📖 It's a **feedback loop with the ruler inside it** — oppression degrades the input that sustains the ruler's own capability. The system is stable only when the peasant is prosperous.

★ **Deploy it in GS4 Ethics** (governance and public welfare), **GS2** (why accountability serves the state's own interest), or **Essay**. NCERT's own question — *is "circle of justice" an appropriate term for the relationship between king and subjects?* — is worth thinking through: it makes the peasant's welfare **instrumental** rather than an end in itself.

⚠️ **Three limitations of the *tawarikh* — know these** ★ ★

#	Limitation
1	Their authors lived in cities (mainly Delhi) and hardly ever in villages — so they describe the court, not the countryside
2	They often wrote for Sultans in the hope of rich rewards — flattery is built in
3	They advised rulers to preserve an "ideal" social order based on BIRTHRIGHT and GENDER DISTINCTIONS — ★ and NCERT adds: "Their ideas were not shared by everybody."

★ ★ **That third point is the chapter's sharpest move.** The chroniclers are not neutral observers — **they are advocates for a hierarchical order**, and they judge rulers by how well those rulers preserved it. So when Barani calls Muhammad Tughluq incompetent for promoting a cook, **you are reading an elite's outrage, not an administrative assessment.**

This is directly usable for the **2020 Mains question** on Persian literary sources reflecting the spirit of the age.

Two definitions NCERT supplies:

- **Birthright** — privileges claimed on account of birth (e.g. nobles inheriting the right to govern because of the family they were born into)
- **Gender distinctions** — social and biological differences between women and men, **usually used to argue that men are superior to women**

3 ★ ★ ★ **Raziyya — and the Problem of a Woman Ruler**

Fact	Detail
Who	Daughter of Sultan Iltutmish
Became Sultan	1236
Removed	1240
What the chronicler said	Minhaj-us-Siraj recognised that she was more able and qualified than her brothers — but was not comfortable at having a queen as ruler
The nobles	Were not happy at her attempts to rule independently

★ **Minhaj-us-Siraj's objection, in his own words:**

"In the register of God's creation, since her account did not fall under the column of men, how did she gain from all of her excellent qualities?"

🔗 **Unpack that sentence, because it is the whole argument in miniature.** He **concedes her excellence** and then says it cannot count — because she is filed under the wrong column. **The objection is not to her competence but to her category.** Minhaj believed her rule went against the ideal social order created by God, in which women were subordinate to men.

★ **This is one of the best short texts in the whole NCERT corpus for a GS1 gender answer.** It shows discrimination operating *despite* acknowledged merit — which is exactly the argument made about structural barriers today.

👑 Three queens compared ★★

Queen	Where / When	How she presented herself
RAZIYYA	Delhi Sultanate, 1236–1240	On her inscriptions and coins she mentioned that she was the daughter of Sultan Iltutmish
RUDRAMADEVI	Kakatiya dynasty of Warangal (modern Andhra Pradesh), 1262–1289	★ Changed her name on her inscriptions and pretended she was a MAN
DIDDA	Kashmir , 980–1003	Her title comes from " didi ", meaning elder sister — an affectionate term given by her subjects to a loved ruler

💡 **Three different strategies for the same problem:** Raziyya **claimed dynastic legitimacy** through her father; Rudramadevi **disguised her gender**; Didda was **embraced by her subjects** on affectionate terms. Learning all three gives you a genuinely comparative answer rather than a single anecdote.

4 Administration — The Loyalty Problem and Its Solution

🔗 **Bandagan** ★★★

Governing a kingdom as vast as the Sultanate needed **reliable governors and administrators**. But aristocrats and landed chieftains had their **own** power bases and could not be trusted.

The solution:

Term	BANDAGAN (Persian)
What	Special slaves purchased for military service
Who favoured them	The early Delhi Sultans, especially ILTUTMISH ★
How used	Carefully trained to fill some of the most important political offices
★ Why	Since they were totally dependent upon their master, the Sultan could trust and rely upon them

NCERT's own framing, from the advice given to Sultans:

"A slave, whom one has brought up and promoted, must be looked after..." — and the pointed question: "**Can you think of any reason why a slave would be better than a son?**"

 **The answer is the key insight of the chapter.** A son has an **independent claim** — he inherits status regardless of your favour, and he has rivals with equally independent claims. A *bandagan* has **no standing except what you granted**, and therefore **no alternative allegiance**. You are not hiring loyalty; you are engineering a situation in which disloyalty has nowhere to go.

The Sultans deliberately built an elite with no inheritable social capital. That is a genuinely clever solution to the principal-agent problem — and it explains why "slave" here means something utterly unlike plantation slavery: these were the **most powerful men in the empire**, and one of them, **Qutbuddin Aybak**, founded the dynasty.

 ...and why it backfired ★ ★

The **Khaljis and Tughluqs** continued using *bandagan* and also **raised people of humble birth** — often their **clients** — to high political positions as **generals and governors**.

THE FATAL FLAW

Slaves and clients were loyal to their MASTERS and PATRONS
-- but NOT to their HEIRS.

Each Sultan had HIS OWN servants.

|
v

So the ACCESSION OF A NEW MONARCH regularly meant
CONFLICT between the old Sultan's men and the new one's.

|
v

POLITICAL INSTABILITY, built in.

 **This is a lovely structural point for a Mains answer:** the mechanism that solved the loyalty problem *within* a reign **created a succession crisis at the end of every reign**. Personal loyalty does not institutionalise. Compare it with the Mauryan single-point-of-failure problem (Class 6 Ch.7) — **both empires solved for control and failed to solve for continuity**.

A *client* = someone under the protection of another; a dependent.

 Muhammad Tughluq's appointments ★ ★

Sultan **Muhammad Tughluq** appointed to high administrative posts:

Name	Former occupation
Aziz Khummar	A wine distiller
Firuz Hajjam	A barber
Manka Tabbakh	A cook
Ladha and Pira	Two gardeners

★ **Ziyauddin Barani**, a mid-fourteenth-century chronicler, reported these appointments as "a sign of the Sultan's loss of political judgement and his incapacity to rule."

 **NCERT asks: "Why do you think Barani criticised the Sultan?"** — and the answer is the point of the whole section. **Barani was an elite defending birthright** (see the *tawarikh* limitations above). To him, a cook in high office was self-evidently absurd. To a modern reader it looks like **appointment on merit rather than birth**.

★ **Same evidence, opposite readings, depending on whose values you apply.** That is a superb, concrete illustration of source bias — and one of the most quotable examples in the book. **The patronage of these humble people also shocked many elites**, and the authors of the *tawarikh* criticised the Sultans for it.

5 ★ ★ ★ The *Iqta* System

Term	Meaning
<i>IQTA</i>	A territory assigned to a military commander in place of a salary
<i>MUQTI</i> / <i>IQTADAR</i>	The holder of an iqta

The muqti's duties:

1. **Lead military campaigns**
2. **Maintain law and order** in his iqta

In exchange: he **collected the revenues of his assignment as salary**, and **paid his soldiers from those revenues**.

The controls — this is what UPSC asks about

HOW THE SULTANS STOPPED IQTAS BECOMING HEREDITARY KINGDOMS

- [1] Control over iqtas was NOT INHERITABLE
- [2] Iqtas were assigned for only a SHORT PERIOD before the holder was SHIFTED elsewhere
- [3] ACCOUNTANTS appointed by the state CHECKED the amount of revenue collected
- [4] Care was taken that the muqti collected ONLY the taxes PRESCRIBED by the state
- [5] ...and that he kept the REQUIRED NUMBER OF SOLDIERS

These harsh conditions were RIGOROUSLY IMPOSED during the reigns of ALAUDDIN KHALJI and MUHAMMAD TUGHLUQ.

★ ★ **Contrast this directly with Class 6 Ch.9's land grants.** Gupta-era *brahmadeya* grants were **permanent, hereditary and tax-free** — and the state slowly dissolved. The *iqta* is the **deliberate opposite: non-hereditary, rotated, audited**. **The Sultans had learned the lesson that the Guptas hadn't.**

 It's the difference between **granting ownership** and **granting a revocable, time-boxed, audited lease with performance conditions**. Same delegation problem; a far better-designed contract.

6 Revenue and Taxes

Alauddin Khalji's reforms ★★

As the Sultans brought the hinterland under control, they **forced the landed chieftains (aristocrats) and rich landlords to accept their authority**.

Under Alauddin Khalji:

Reform
The state brought the assessment and collection of land revenue under its own control
The rights of local chieftains to levy taxes were CANCELLED
They themselves were forced to pay taxes
The Sultan's administrators measured the land and kept careful accounts
Some old chieftains and landlords served the Sultanate as revenue collectors and assessors

The three taxes ★★★

Tax	On what	Rate
★ KHARAJ	Cultivation	About 50 per cent of the peasant's produce
(2)	Cattle	—
(3)	Houses	—

★ "Kharaj $\approx$ 50% of produce" is a very high-frequency Prelims fact. Compare it with the Mauryan/mahajanapada *bhaga* = $1/6$ (Class 6 Ch.5). **The state's claim on the peasant tripled over roughly 1,500 years.** That comparison is worth carrying into an answer on the evolution of the agrarian tax burden.

Other taxes named in the chapter

Tax	Detail
KHUMS	One-fifth — of war booty, and on mines
ZAKAT	The alms tax obligatory on Muslims
JIZYAH ★	Levied on non-Muslims who had been given protection by the state; collected along with the land tax . Levied under both the Delhi Sultans and the Mughals

7 The Limits of Sultanate Power

Internal and external frontiers ★★

Frontier	What it meant
INTERNAL frontier	Consolidating the hinterland of the garrison towns — bringing the countryside around Delhi under direct control, forcing local chieftains to submit
EXTERNAL frontier	Military expeditions into distant regions — southern India, Bengal, the Deccan

⚠️ What the Sultanate could NOT hold

"Large parts of the subcontinent remained outside the control of the Delhi Sultans."

Limit	Detail
Distance	It was difficult to govern provinces like Bengal from Delhi
The south	Soon after annexing southern India, the entire region became independent
Forests	★ Even in the Gangetic plain there were forested areas that Sultanate forces could not penetrate , where local chieftains established their rule
Temporary success	Rulers like Alauddin Khalji and Muhammad Tughluq could force control in these areas — but only for a short duration

🔗 **This is Ch.5's setup** (Tribes, Nomads and Settled Communities) and it echoes the Mauryan *atavika* problem from Class 6 Ch.7. **Empires in India controlled corridors and cities far more effectively than they controlled forests.**

★ **Ibn Battuta** — a **fourteenth-century traveller from Morocco, Africa** — described how chieftains arranged for their **defence and fortifications**. (He is a standard Prelims name: a Moroccan who travelled to India in Muhammad Tughluq's reign and served as a *qazi* in Delhi; his account is the *Rihla*.)

🐎 The Mongols ★★

Fact	Detail
Who	The Mongols under Genghis Khan
What	Invaded Transoxiana in north-east Iran in 1219 ★
Then	The Delhi Sultanate faced their onslaught soon after
Peak pressure	Attacks increased during the reign of Alauddin Khalji and in the early years of Muhammad Tughluq's rule
★ The consequence	This forced the two rulers to mobilise a large standing army in Delhi — which posed a huge administrative challenge

🔗 **Follow the causal chain, because this is how a good answer is structured: Mongol threat → large standing army → army must be paid → hence Alauddin's harsh revenue measures, price control and rigorous *iqta* audits.** The famous severity of Alauddin Khalji's administration is **a response to an external military emergency**, not merely personal temperament.

8 The Sultanate in the 15th and 16th Centuries

After the Tughluqs, the **Sayyid** and **Lodi** dynasties ruled from **Delhi and Agra**.

Meanwhile, independent rulers established themselves in: Jaunpur, Bengal, Malwa, Gujarat, Rajasthan and the entire south India.

★ Some of these regional states were **small but powerful and extremely well administered**. This is the period that saw the **emergence of new ruling groups like the AFGHANS and the RAJPUTS**.

✂ Sher Shah Suri ★★ ★

Fact	Detail
Started as	Manager of a small territory for his uncle in Bihar ★
Rose to	Challenged and defeated the Mughal emperor Humayun
Ruled	1540 – 1555
His administration	Borrowed elements from Alauddin Khalji and made them more efficient
★★ The legacy	It became the model followed by the great emperor AKBAR (1556–1605) when he consolidated the Mughal Empire

★ This single sentence is the bridge to Chapter 4, and it's frequently asked. The line of descent is:

Alauddin Khalji → Sher Shah Suri → Akbar.

Mughal administration was **not invented from nothing** — it was inherited, refined Sultanate practice. Saying so in a Mains answer immediately signals that you understand institutional continuity rather than treating each dynasty as a fresh start.

💡 **Worth knowing beyond the text** (Sher Shah is asked about more than this chapter covers): he reorganised land revenue with systematic **survey and measurement**, issued the silver **rupiya** (ancestor of the rupee), built the **Grand Trunk Road** (Sadak-e-Azam) with *sarais*, and organised an efficient postal system. His tomb at **Sasaram** is a major monument.

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Pre-Sultanate Delhi ★	Tomaras → Chauhans of Ajmer ; Jaina merchants ; coins called dehliwal
Five dynasties ★ ★ ★	Slave/Early Turkish (1206–1290) → Khalji (1290–1320) → Tughluq (1320–1414) → Sayyid (1414–1451) → Lodi (1451–1526)
Qutbuddin Aybak	1206–1210 , first Sultan
Iltutmish ★	Favoured bandagan
Raziyya ★ ★ ★	1236–1240 ; daughter of Iltutmish ; chronicler Minhaj-us-Siraj
Rudramadevi ★ ★	Kakatiya, Warangal, 1262–1289 ; pretended to be a man on inscriptions
Didida ★	Kashmir, 980–1003 ; name from " didi ", elder sister
Tarikh*/tawarikh ★ ★	Histories, in PERSIAN ; three limitations
Circle of justice ★ ★	Fakhr-i Mudabbir , 13th century
Bandagan ★ ★ ★	Special slaves bought for military service; trusted because totally dependent
Muhammad Tughluq's officials ★ ★	Aziz Khummar (wine distiller), Firuz Hajjam (barber), Manka Tabbakh (cook), Ladha & Pira (gardeners)
Ziyauddin Barani ★ ★	Mid-14th-c. chronicler; called the appointments a sign of the Sultan's incapacity to rule
Iqta* / muqti / *iqtadar ★ ★ ★	Assignment in place of salary; not inheritable, rotated, audited by state accountants
Kharaj ★ ★ ★	Tax on cultivation, ≈50% of produce
Khums / zakat / jizyah ★ ★	One-fifth of booty & mines / alms tax on Muslims / tax on protected non-Muslims
Alauddin Khalji's reforms ★ ★	State took over assessment and collection ; chieftains' taxing rights cancelled ; land measured
Internal vs external frontier ★	Hinterland consolidation vs distant expeditions
Mongols ★ ★	Genghis Khan, Transoxiana, 1219 ; forced a large standing army
Ibn Battuta ★	Fourteenth century , from Morocco
Sher Shah Suri ★ ★ ★	1540–1555 ; began in Bihar ; defeated Humayun ; borrowed from Alauddin Khalji ; model for Akbar

Traps:

- "Delhi was a major capital from ancient times" → **FALSE**. Important only from the **12th century**
- "Bandagan were agricultural slaves" → **FALSE**. Elite military slaves holding **the highest offices**
- "Iqtas were hereditary" → **FALSE**. Explicitly **not inheritable**, and holders were **rotated**
- "Raziyya was removed because she was incompetent" → **FALSE**. Minhaj-us-Siraj called her **more able than her brothers**; the objection was to her **gender**
- "Rudramadevi ruled the Kakatiyas of Warangal in Karnataka" → **FALSE**. Warangal is in modern Andhra Pradesh/Telangana
- "Kharaj was one-sixth of produce" → **FALSE**. That's the ancient *bhaga*; kharaj was about **50%**
- "Akbar devised Mughal administration from scratch" → **FALSE**. He followed **Sher Shah's** model

Mains

- **Source criticism** ★★ ★: "*Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age.*" (2020) — use the *tawarikh*, their three limitations, the circle of justice, and Barani on Muhammad Tughluq
- **Gender (GS1)** ★★: Raziyya, Rudramadevi and Didda — three strategies for exercising power in a patriarchal order; Minhaj's "column of men" quotation
- **Administration** ★★: the *iqta* as a designed solution to the delegation problem — contrast with Gupta land grants
- **State capacity**: the Sultanate's internal/external frontiers and the forests it never controlled
- **Institutional continuity** ★: Alauddin Khalji → Sher Shah → Akbar

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Dehliwal	Coins minted at Delhi under the Tomaras and Chauhans
Tarikh / Tawarikh	History / histories, written in Persian
Circle of justice	The argument linking just rule → prosperous peasants → revenue → soldiers → the king
Birthright	Privileges claimed on account of birth
Gender distinctions	Social and biological differences used to argue men are superior to women
Bandagan	Special slaves purchased for military service
Client	Someone under another's protection; a dependent
Iqta	Territory assigned in place of a salary
Muqti / Iqtadar	Holder of an iqta
Kharaj	Tax on cultivation, about 50% of produce
Khums	One-fifth share (war booty, mines)
Zakat	Alms tax obligatory on Muslims
Jizyah	Tax on protected non-Muslims
Garrison town	A fortified settlement with soldiers
Internal frontier	The hinterland being brought under control
External frontier	Distant regions targeted by military expeditions

90-Second Recap

1. **Delhi mattered only from the 12th century** — **Tomaras**, then **Chauhans of Ajmer**; a commercial centre with **Jaina merchants** and **dehliwal** coins.
2. **Five dynasties**: Early Turkish/Slave (1206) → **Khalji** (1290) → **Tughluq** (1320) → **Sayyid** (1414) → **Lodi** (1451–1526).
3. **Histories** = *tawarikh*, in **PERSIAN**, by courtiers who **lived in cities, wrote for reward, and defended birthright and gender hierarchy**.
4. **The circle of justice (Fakhr-i Mudabbir)**: king → soldiers → salaries → revenue → prosperous peasants → just rule → king.

5. **Raziyya (1236–1240): Minhaj-us-Siraj** admitted she was abler than her brothers but objected that she was not in "the column of men". Compare **Rudramadevi** (posed as a man) and **Didda** ("elder sister").
 6. **Bandagan** — military slaves, favoured by **Iltutmish**, trusted **because totally dependent**. But they were loyal to masters, **not heirs**, so **every succession brought conflict**.
 7. **Muhammad Tughluq** promoted a **wine distiller, a barber, a cook and two gardeners**; **Barani** called it proof of incapacity — **which tells us more about Barani than about the Sultan**.
 8. **Iqta** assignments were **non-inheritable, rotated and audited**, with the state checking revenue and troop numbers — **rigorously under Alauddin Khalji and Muhammad Tughluq**.
 9. **Alauddin Khalji** took revenue assessment and collection into state hands, **cancelled chieftains' taxing rights** and **measured the land**. Taxes: **kharaj (~50% of produce)**, cattle, houses. Also **khums, zakat, jizyah**.
 10. **The Sultanate never controlled everything** — Bengal was far, the south broke away, and **forests even in the Gangetic plain stayed beyond reach**.
 11. **Mongols under Genghis Khan** hit **Transoxiana in 1219**; the resulting threat forced a **large standing army**, which drove the harsh revenue regime.
 12. **Sher Shah Suri (1540–1555)** rose from managing a small Bihar territory, **defeated Humayun**, refined **Alauddin Khalji's system** — and **became the model for Akbar**.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements about the *bandagan*:
 1. They were slaves purchased for military service.
 2. They were preferred because they were entirely dependent on the Sultan.
 3. The system made succession more stable. → *1 and 2 only. It made succession **less** stable, since they were loyal to masters rather than heirs.*
2. Which of the following restrictions applied to an *iqta*?
 1. It was not inheritable. 2. Its holder was periodically transferred. 3. State accountants audited the revenue collected. → *All three.*
3. Raziyya was removed from the throne primarily because — → *The chronicler and the nobles objected to a woman ruling, and to her attempts to rule independently — not to her ability.*
4. Consider the following pairs:
 1. Rudramadevi — Kakatiya dynasty of Warangal
 2. Didda — Kashmir
 3. Raziyya — daughter of Qutbuddin Aybak → *1 and 2 only. Raziyya was the daughter of **Iltutmish**.*
5. The tax called *kharaj* was levied on — → *Cultivation, at about 50 per cent of the peasant's produce.*
6. Sher Shah Suri's administration — → *Borrowed from Alauddin Khalji, was made more efficient, and became the model followed by Akbar.*

Mains style

7. "Persian chronicles of the Delhi Sultanate tell us as much about their authors as about the events they record." Discuss. (250 words)

8. Examine the *iqta* system as a solution to the problem of delegating authority, contrasting it with earlier land grants. **(250 words)**
9. "*Raziyya's reign illustrates that acknowledged merit was no protection against structural prejudice.*" Comment. **(150 words)**
10. Assess the administrative continuity between the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal Empire. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name the five dynasties in order with approximate dates.
- State the circle of justice in five steps.
- Why were slaves preferred to sons, and what did that cost the Sultanate?
- List the five controls placed on a *muqti*.
- Give the three taxes under Alauddin Khalji and the rate of *kharaj*.
- What did the Mongol threat force the Sultans to do, and what followed from it?
- Trace the line from Alauddin Khalji to Akbar.